for incidents of a communal nature. Lajpat also introduced me to the prominent locals of the area, whom we could call in case of need. One such person was Dr K Hemchandra, on Vidyalam Road, a well-known and esteemed figure who was respected by all—the militants, the Sri Lankan Army as well as by us, and some of us are still in touch with him. After handing over to me, Lajpat returned to the HQ to take over as the Adjutant, and Captain Ramesh Menon became my Company 2iC.

The Company HQ was located on the top floor of a girl's school, which was functioning on a reduced scale. Opposite the HQ was the shop of the 'Chinaman', a vendor who had all the latest in foreign goods, sourced from God knows where. From TVs to VCRs (they were the craze then) to music systems; to chocolates and perfumes; decorative items of all kinds; Danish cookies and coconut milk; even gold coins. You name it, he had it. It was like a mini duty-free shop. All ranks would make a beeline to this shop before proceeding on leave, buying whatever they could afford. Sales were high, spurred no doubt by the two beautiful salesgirls, rumoured to be his daughters. On this account, we, i.e. Bravo Company, had to make sure that there was no untoward incident at the shop, no firing or IED anywhere around nor any cases of theft or arson. The days and nights were an endless round of maintaining the highest level of alertness and security, leaving no time to appreciate either the beauty of the bay, or the beauties on the beach.

My class fellow-cum-coursemate Nandu Koregaonkar was also in Trincomalee. His unit,1 PARA (SF), had been one of the first units to be inducted and had carried out countless operations and suffered many casualties. Nandu had been seriously injured himself, when during a search and destroy operation, a Claymore mine had gone off, spraying him with shrapnel and injuring him critically. After recovering from his

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